

Country Cure

A green and spacious retreat outside the city helps revitalise mentally challenged inmates



PANAAH INMATES AT A MUSIC SESSION

| By Ambreesh Mishra |

Even after cheering the Indian team's win over the visiting Aussies at Kotla on their lone television set late into the night, the inmates of Panaah were talking about it the next morning. Once they were through with their routine chores and psychotherapy, these 23 mentally challenged young men decided to celebrate the victory with a round of singing and music—even if the melody was out of tune.

Surrounded by farms, the inmates of Panaah, a residential facility for non-violent mentally challenged people in Katara Hills, just outside Bhopal, have benefited greatly by the bright sunlight and country air. "Living in the open countryside has had a therapeutic effect in managing their problems," says their therapist Gunjan Shukla. Panaah, christened as such by lyricist and filmmaker Gulzar, blends a social outreach programme for the mentally challenged with environmental concerns. "Expensive land prices in Bhopal forced us to locate it away from the city," says Anil Mudgal of Panaah. But that brought accompanying problems like long power cuts and lack of piped water. This forced them to innovate and

they decided to setup a biogas plant for cooking and as their primary source of energy. Four solar lanterns provide the back-up while a generator provides round-the-clock power for lighting, fans and pumping water.

A dairy provides milk to inmates and dung for the biogas plant; its organic waste is turned into vermicompost and sold to corporates. Surplus milk is sold too. A small kitchen garden supplies vegetables to the inmates, who work on the kitchen garden, vermicompost pit and at the dairy. "The sense of self-worth from these activities has helped bring improvement in their behaviour," says warden Sachin Devaliya. Nishul Gautam, 30, who is visually and mentally challenged, has made the most improvement, making efforts to water and tend to his saplings twice a day. Another inmate Saurabh Pare, 28, feels it's better than his village home.

"They have turned adversity into opportunity," says Commissioner of Social Welfare M. Mohan Rao. Panaah's efforts have demonstrated a low-cost model for rehabilitation institutions that the government now wants to emulate across the state. ■